Hiking Safety Checklist

From the free guide at https://jaechung-glitch.github.io/bugout/guides/what-to-do-if-lost-in-the-woods/, which lists its sources (National Park Service, American Hiking Society and FCC guidance). Updated November 12, 2026.

General safety information, not medical advice or a substitute for training. In an emergency, call 911.

What to do when you’re lost

1. **Stop, think, observe, plan.** Panic makes people walk faster in the wrong direction. Drink some water, eat something, and take stock.
2. **Try to orient yourself.** Check your map, compass or GPS app. Look for trail markers, and backtrack carefully only if you're confident.
3. **Stay put if you're not sure.** Moving makes you harder to find. Leave only to find water, and return to the same spot.
4. **Call for help.** Call 911 if you have any signal. Give the trail name, landmarks and your coordinates. If a call won't connect, try texting 911. Then save your battery.
5. **Make yourself visible.** Move to the nearest open area. Spread bright clothing or gear where it can be seen from above.
6. **Signal in threes.** Three whistle blasts, three shouts or three flashes is the universal distress call. Repeat at intervals.
7. **Prepare for the night.** Shelter comes before food: get out of wind and off cold ground well before dark.

How not to get lost

- [ ] Leave a trip plan with someone: where you're going, your route and when you'll be back
- [ ] Carry a paper map and compass, and know how to use them
- [ ] Download offline maps before you lose signal
- [ ] Carry a whistle, a mirror and a headlamp
- [ ] Pack extra water, food and a warm layer, even on short hikes
- [ ] Bring a charged phone and a power bank
- [ ] Wear bright clothing
- [ ] Agree on a meet-up spot if your group gets separated
- [ ] Look back often so you'll recognize the trail on the way out